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DEVENDRA FADNAVIS 54
Chief Minister, Maharashtra
EKNATH SHINDE 60/ AJIT PAWAR 65
Deputy Chief Ministers

THE MAHA BONDING

At one time, Fadnavis, Shinde and Ajit Pawar were seen as an unwieldy trio with mutually subversive intent. A bumper assembly poll harvest inverts that

By Dhaval S. Kulkarni



ANI

MAHAYUTI TRIO
(L-R) Shinde, Fadnavis and Pawar

If there was any trace of worry within the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) ahead of the big battle in November, they were good at hiding it. More likely, they were luxuriating in how well the Lok Sabha election had gone: 31 of Maharashtra's 48 seats, leads in 153 assembly segments. A comfortable buffer. Too comfortable. The Opposition triad fought over the fruits of war much before they had ripened. Meanwhile, there was another triumvirate, plotting away at a different script—the three horsemen of the MVA's apocalypse. Devendra Fadnavis, Ajit Pawar and Eknath Shinde: one allegedly not a mass leader, one with an apparently shrinking base, and one with his soufflé rising but perhaps not enough to pull up the other two. They gave the sense of being unequal to the task. That's what imparted the suddenness of an ambush to the Mahayuti's magisterial sweep.

Shinde had been the riddle at the heart of the Mahayuti experiment since its birth. Initially, the jury was always out on his political longevity. But it was folly to under-estimate a man who had risen through tragedy and adversity through sheer grit. That too one mentored by Anand Dighe, who almost rivalled Bal Thackeray in stature in his stronghold of Thane. The first inkling that Shinde was no pushover came with the Maratha agitation. Even if hints that he was its secret author were not true, as a Maratha he played the field with tact and authority as everyone else scurried for cover. That mastery over the ground, belying a politician who was said to have no great base to speak of, was confirmed when the Lok Sabha results came. He notched an impressive tally of seven seats, just two less than that of the rival Sena. His claim to owning the 'real Sena' was not just legal skullduggery, after all. There was thus an air of imperious control thereafter when he unfurled a welfare umbrella, including the flagship Ladki Bahin scheme, that finally covered nearly 55 million Maharashtrians. If anyone was looking for a game-changer, it was right there, hiding in plain sight. His current takehome: a princely 57 seats.

As for Ajit *dada*, everyone agreed he was the weakest link in the Mahayuti—even those within. The naysayers could be forgiven: Ajit's NCP had a stark lack of sync with the Sangh-BJP base, who had always seen him as a foe. And uncle Sharad, the old maestro, wouldn't sit back and be upstaged anyway. That impression deepened when Ajit's NCP won just one of the four Lok Sabha seats it contested. Even his wife Sunetra lost from Baramati, to Pawar Sr's daughter Supriya Sule. No one expected Ajit to pull up his socks. But he engaged politi-